scendo after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) did not name Ajit and his wife Sunetra in a chargesheet in a case about the auction of a sugar mill in Satara at an undervalued price by the Maharashtra State Co-operative Bank (MSCB) when he was on its board. On his part, Ajit said that the ED had not given him a clean chit and a probe was underway.

The Supreme Court has finished hearing a bunch of petitions on the change of guard in Maharashtra. If Shinde and 15 of his MLAs are disqualified under the provisions of the anti-defection law, the BJP may need more numbers to shore up support in the legislature. But while Ajit has dismissed any reports about his impending tie-up with the BJP or about any meeting with senior BJP leaders, at least two NCP MLAs—Manikrao Kokate and Anna Bansode—have said in public that they will support Ajit's decision.

After Ajit went public with his denial, a senior Congress leader said that any coup may have been put off for now due to the reluctance of the BJP leadership considering the Karnataka polls and the impending SC verdict. Unease in the Shinde camp may have also led to a rethink. Sanjay Shirsat, MLA and spokesperson of the Shinde-led Shiv Sena, said that they would welcome Ajit if he joined them, but warned that they were not willing to participate in a government which had the NCP as a partner.

Earlier, the tremors of these developments were felt in the MVA. Thackeray and his Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut met Pawar Senior and his daughter Supriya Sule, the Lok Sabha MP from Baramati, at Pawar's Mumbai home. On April 16, Raut in his weekly column in party mouthpiece *Saamana* wrote that the BJP was trying to use agencies like the ED to break the NCP. During the meeting, he elaborated, Pawar said "no one wants to leave by their free will, but the family is being targeted". Raut said Pawar had assured them that even if some from the NCP left in their individual capacity, the party would never align with the BJP. Thackeray and his men have claimed that their legislators joined Shinde's coup to evade the heat from the enforcement agencies. Former CM and senior Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan has said that the ruling coalition is making attempts to break the MVA and launch its 'Operation Kamal' to engineer defections in the opposition.



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THE SENA'S SANJAY RAUT SAID SHARAD PAWAR HAD ASSURED THEM THAT EVEN IF SOME FROM THE NCP LEFT IN THEIR INDIVIDUAL CAPACITY, THE PARTY WOULD NEVER ALIGN WITH THE BJP

Speaking to a Marathi news channel earlier, Pawar, when asked about Ajit's short-lived dalliance with the BJP and whether it could be repeated, had said: "It cannot be said today what position someone will take tomorrow." A senior leader of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) admits to a churn within the NCP, with some leaders eager to join hands with the BJP, but says that Pawar Senior is "firmly with the MVA". This is corroborated by one of his party colleagues with roots in the NCP. "The course of events will be based on how these currents and counter-currents play out," he notes. This leader says that Pawar may have defended Adani Group chairperson Gautam Adani at a personal level rather than a political one. Hence, political motives must not be read into it, he adds.

In his autobiography, *Lok Majhe Sangati...* (2015), Pawar writes glowingly about Adani and calls him a hard-working, self-made and grounded man. Pawar says while Adani got into the business of providing coal for thermal power projects, he (Pawar) suggested that he could also take to developing power projects. Adani Power has also developed a 3,300 MW thermal power plant in Gondia, which is the base of senior NCP leader Praful Patel.

Two senior BJP leaders confirm that back-channel talks with NCP leaders are underway. "This is why the expansion of the state cabinet has been put off for long... But contrary to speculation, any defections from the NCP will not take place with an eye on the likely SC verdict. This is being done